ON CALL SHEET: the weekly cover tabs

Conventions and protocols for dispatch and management, SLICs staff and cover drivers · November 11, 2026

The SLICs app shows each cover driver the week's jobs, their place on the pick list and their call-in time. It reads all of it from the ON CALL SHEET, within a minute of each edit. **The app never writes to the sheet, and can't.** The sheet is the record and the app is a copy of it. The app reads the text in the cells and nothing else (no colors, no comments), so what matters has to be typed in a cell, the same way every week.

Where this comes from: the 30 weekly tabs from May to November 2026, and every change the app recorded from October 14 to November 11 (5,614 changed cells). Most of what follows is already how the sheet is kept. The points below are the ones that slipped at least once, and what each slip did in the app.

Posting a week: the checklist

- ☐ **1** The tab's name is the week-ending Saturday's date and nothing else: `11/21/2026`
- ☐ **2** The title row says the same date: `JOBS AVAILABLE FOR W/E 11.21.2026`
- ☐ **3** The two header rows are as they've always been (`Job #` … `Description`, and `NAME` … `PICK #7`).
- ☐ **4** Every job row has its **Job #**, in capitals, listed once.
- ☐ **5** Start times are 24-hour `HH:MM`. A day the job doesn't run is left blank.
- ☐ **6** **NAME** on a job row is blank while the job is open. Once taken: the driver's name as the pick list spells it, or `CUT`. A note starts with an asterisk: `*COVER DAY-BY-DAY`
- ☐ **7** Pick list: every driver once, `LAST, FIRST`, spelled as last week.
- ☐ **8** Pick numbers run 1, 2, 3… down the list with no repeats. 1 to 20 are the cover drivers. Everyone after number 20 is on call.
- ☐ **9** A cover driver who's out keeps their row, with no call-in time and no number. Their number is skipped.
- ☐ **10** The cell before `PICK #1` says what the driver is doing that week, in the standard words (page 3).

Changing a posted week: the protocol

- **Finish one row before starting the next,** and make related changes in one sitting. Drivers see each edit within a minute.
- **When a driver picks,** write their name on the job's row *and* the job code on their own row. Both, right away.
- **Renumbering or re-timing the pick list:** do all of it at once. Each driver is told their call-in time 30 minutes after the list stops changing.
- **Sort, cut and paste whole rows,** never one column.
- **Bid day moved for a holiday?** Tell a SLICs admin. The sheet doesn't say which day the bid is, so the app has to be told.
- **Something looks wrong in the app?** Check the sheet first. If the sheet is right and the app isn't, tell a SLICs admin.

REQUIRED The app can't read the week, or shows drivers something wrong, without it.
HELPS The app copes, but everyone reads it more easily.

The layout the app reads (every name here is made up)

JOBS AVAILABLE FOR W/E 11.21.2026									← **title row: same date as the tab's name**
Job #	**NAME**	**Assigned Driver**	**Cover Reason**	**Sun**	**Mon**	**Tues … Fri**	**Sat**	**Description**	← job header, never renamed
LV57	DOE, JANE	SMITH, JOHN	VACATION		07:00	07:00		Mon-Fri: BETPA>LANPA>BETPA	← taken: the name as the pick list spells it
BE11			VACANT	21:30	21:30	21:30		Sun-Thu: BETPA>NEWPA>BETPA	← open: NAME is blank
XTR4	CUT		PEAK JOB		10:00	10:00		Mon-Fri: BETPA>AILPA>BETPA	← cut: says CUT, shows as taken
PK17	*COVER DAY-BY-DAY		PEAK JOB		09:00	09:00		Mon-Fri: BETPA>NEWPA>BETPA	← a note, not a driver: starts with *
one blank row, nothing else, between the jobs and the pick list									
	NAME			**PICK #1 … PICK #7**					← pick header, never renamed
07:00	DOE, JANE	1	LV57						← call-in time · name · pick number · job / status
07:15	ROE, RICHARD	2							← hasn't picked yet: job / status is blank
	POE, ANN		VACATION						← out this week: no time, no number, 3 is skipped
	*VACANT								← not a driver: starts with *, the app skips the row
07:45	LEE, SAM	4							
13:00	KIM, ALEX	21	ON CALL						← after number 20: on call

1 · The tab and the job list

The tab

- REQUIRED **Name it with the date only:** `11/21/2026`, the Saturday the week ends. Any other word in the name and the app doesn't read the tab. That's on purpose: `ON CALL 11/14/2026`, `HUB Drivers…`, `SHIFTERS` and `Copy of…` are never read.
- REQUIRED **The title row carries the same date.** When a new week starts as a copy of the last one, the title is the easy thing to miss. If it's missing or says another week, the app saves nothing for that week.
  Seen: 2 tabs since May had no title row (5/16, 8/15) and 2 said another date (7/4 said 6.27, 8/22 said 8.20).
- REQUIRED **Leave the two header rows as they are.** The app finds each column by its header text, so a row or a column can be added anywhere without harm. A renamed header can't be found.
  Seen: identical in all 30 tabs. Nothing to change.
- REQUIRED **One week, one tab.** With two tabs of the same date, the app reads the first one only.
- HELPS **Build next week under a working name** (`DRAFT 11/28`) and rename it to the date when it's ready. Nobody sees a draft: drivers get one "Cover jobs posted" for the finished week, not the week being typed in.
  Seen: W/E 11/21 was built in the open over four days: 166 jobs added and 142 removed along the way, for a list of 51.
- HELPS **Hiding a job's row hides it from drivers** in the app (admins still see it). That's how the shifter jobs at the top are kept out today. So don't hide a row drivers should see, and hide one they shouldn't. Sleeper jobs (`ER` and a number) are never shown to drivers.

Job

- REQUIRED **Every job row has one, typed first.** A new row with times but no number shows drivers a job with no name.
- REQUIRED **One number, one job, for the whole week.** Drivers' lists, the admins' "hide" and the change history all follow the number. A number reused for a different job that week carries the old job's lists with it.
- HELPS **Capitals, no spaces, no notes:** `CPU2`, not `cpu2` or `ER18013?`. The app treats them as the same job, but drivers see it as typed.
- HELPS **List a job once.** When the same number is on two rows on purpose (a two-driver sleeper team, a shifter job shown twice), the app keeps both, but hiding one hides both.
  Seen: 26 repeated numbers in 16 weeks, all `ER` or `SH`, plus `CPU4` twice on 11/21.

NAME (who took the job)

- REQUIRED **Blank means open.** Any text at all in this cell and drivers see the job as taken. A note for drivers about an open job goes in Description, which they can read.
- REQUIRED **Cut job:** `CUT`**.** Drivers see it as taken, which is right.
- REQUIRED **A note starts with an asterisk:** `*COVER DAY-BY-DAY`**.** The asterisk tells the app the words aren't a driver's name. Drivers still see the job as taken, and never the note. Admins see it labeled "Note".
  Seen: about a dozen notes under NAME in 19 weeks (covered day by day, nobody to cover). Without the asterisk, the app takes each for a driver by that name.
- HELPS **Write the name as the pick list has it:** `DOE, JANE`**.** Copy and paste it from the pick list below. A last name alone marks the job taken just the same, but the app can't tell which driver it is, so the driver who took it also gets "a job on your list was taken".
  Seen: of 553 names since August, 61% were a last name only, 30% `LAST, FIRST`, 6% `CUT`. Each week 4 to 11 can't be matched to a pick-list name as written.

Sun to Sat (start times)

- REQUIRED **24-hour** `HH:MM`**:** `07:00`, `15:30`, `21:45`. Blank on a day the job doesn't run. Words go in Description, never in a day's cell.
  Seen: all 2,456 day cells since August are valid times. The only slips on record were half-typed ones (`15:0`, `8:`).

Description (the route)

- HELPS **A day label, a colon, then the stops joined by** `>`**:**
  `Mon-Fri: BETPA>LANPA>BETPA`
  `Sun: BETPA>NEWPA>BETPA` `Mon, Thu: BETPA>AILPA`
  Written this way, the app shows each day's route on the driver's week, and every stop opens that building's address, map and phone.
  Seen: 447 of 492 descriptions since August are written this way. The rest show as plain text.

Assigned Driver and Cover Reason

- Drivers never see these two columns in the app. Admins do.
- HELPS **Assigned Driver:** the name as the Jobs tab has it.
- HELPS **Cover Reason: one of a short list,** spelled the same each week: `VACATION` `FMLA` `VACANT` `PEAK JOB` `NEW JOB` `EXTRA JOB` `COMBO WEEK` `COVERING ER18006` `VOLUNTARY LAYOFF` `REDUCTION OF WORKFORCE` `P/H` `OTHER`
  Seen: nearly 50 wordings in 16 weeks for about a dozen reasons (`PEAK`, `PEAK JOB`, `PEAK ADD`; `VACANT`, `OPEN`, `OPEN JOB`; `VOLUTNARY LAYOFF`).
- HELPS **Keep personal details out.** Anyone with the sheet's link can read it. For a family or medical reason, `OTHER` says enough.
- HELPS **A dropdown does this for you:** select the column, then Data → Data validation → Dropdown, with "Show a warning" so anything can still be typed. One-time setup by the sheet's owner, and it's faster than typing.

2 · The pick list

NAME

- REQUIRED `LAST, FIRST`**, spelled the same every week.** Each driver's SLICs account is linked to their name as the sheet spells it. Capitals, periods and spacing don't matter. A different word does (a nickname, an added middle initial): the app then tells that driver they're not on the week's list.
  Seen: 1,100 rows since August, 122 drivers, not one spelled two ways. This is the part of the sheet that's kept best.
- REQUIRED **Each driver once.** Listed twice, a driver keeps the first row's place and time.
  Seen: one driver listed twice in 4 of the weeks since May.
- REQUIRED **A row that isn't a driver starts with an asterisk:** `*VACANT`. The app skips it. Without the asterisk it's read as a driver with no number.
  Seen: a `VACANT` row on 8/29, read as a driver.

Call-in time (the first column)

- REQUIRED **24-hour** `HH:MM`**, later as the numbers go up.** This is the time the app shows the driver, and reminds them before, on bid day.
- REQUIRED **Blank for a driver who's out.** No time means no reminder.

Pick number (the column after NAME)

- REQUIRED **1, 2, 3… in order, each number once.** The app goes by these numbers and nothing else: 1 to 20 are the week's cover drivers, and everyone listed after number 20 is on call. A repeated number puts a driver in the wrong place.
  Seen: a number repeated in 7 of the 15 weeks read since August (18 twice; 22, 24 and 25 twice). None in the last seven weeks.
- REQUIRED **A cover driver who's out keeps their row, with no number, and their number is skipped** (4, blank, 6). Their place stays theirs and the drivers after them don't move.
- HELPS **Numbers only in this column.** A note here (`TWI AND NIGHT`, `PASS`, `NO ANSWER`) makes the row unnumbered. Notes fit in the job / status cell, or in a column to the right of `PICK #7`, which the app ignores.
  Seen: 55 rows since August, all after number 20, where it does no harm.
- HELPS **Colors aren't read.** Yellow fill, red names and gray rows mean nothing to the app. If it matters, it's in a cell.

PICK #1 to PICK #7

- HELPS Job codes only, as the job list writes them. These columns are mostly empty these days and the app doesn't depend on them.

Job / status (the cell before PICK #1)

- REQUIRED **What the driver is doing that week.** The app shows each driver their own cell, as typed, at the top of their profile. It's also how the app knows who covered which job.
- REQUIRED **When a driver takes a job, fill both places:** their name in the job's NAME cell (drivers see the job as taken) and the job code here (the driver sees their week, with times and route).
  Seen: most weeks, 1 to 4 taken jobs have no driver's row pointing at them, and now and then a driver's row names a job whose NAME is still blank, so the app still offers it.
- HELPS **Use the same few words.** Suggested standard:

Write	The app understands
`LV57`	Covering that job. The code must match a Job # on this week's list.
`COVERING ER18006`	Covering a sleeper team's seat.
`ON CALL`	On call this week.
(blank)	Hasn't picked yet.
`VACATION` · `FMLA` · `BUYOUT`	Off this week.
`PASS` · `DIS` · `LIGHT DUTY` · `WORKERS COMP` · `VOLUNTARY LAYOFF` · `REDUCTION OF WORKFORCE` · `WON LV93`	Shown to the driver as written.
`TWI AND NIGHT (MON-THU)`	Shown as written. One spelling, days in parentheses.

Seen: more than 70 wordings since August for about a dozen meanings. "Twi and night" alone is written more than 15 ways (`TWI & NIGHT`, `TWI AND NIGHT (MON - THRU)`, `TWI & NIGHR`), and voluntary layoff four (`VOLUTNARY LAYOFF`, `VOL LAYOFF`). Once, a file path was pasted here by accident.

- HELPS **Short and neutral.** The driver reads this cell on their phone, and the sheet is open to anyone with the link. A return date is fine (`FMLA - RTW 11/30`). Medical detail isn't needed.
- HELPS **A dropdown fits here too** (Data → Data validation → Dropdown, "Show a warning"), since a job code still has to be typed.

The Jobs tab (every bid job)

- REQUIRED Keep the tab named `Jobs`, its header row as it is, and each **Job Name** on one row only.
- REQUIRED **Sort and paste whole rows.**
  Seen: on 11/3 the Driver and Seniority columns of all 298 jobs changed and changed back within 67 seconds. For that minute the app had the wrong driver on every job.
- HELPS A driver's name here is spelled as on the pick list. The app puts the two together to show a driver their own job.

3 · How a change travels, and who does what

Within a minute
The app re-reads the tab that was edited. Drivers opening Covers see the new cell.

At once
A driver whose list held a job that was just taken or removed is told which, and what's next on their list.

After 10 quiet minutes
Drivers on that week's list are told once what changed: jobs added, removed, new times.

After 30 quiet minutes
Each driver whose place or call-in time ended up different is told the final one.

"Quiet" means no more edits to that part of the sheet. That's why one sitting is kinder than a change every twenty minutes: the first is one notification, the second is one each time. Edits to a week after its Saturday aren't read. A full re-read runs early every morning in case anything was missed. Notifications reach the drivers who turned them on.

What the last four weeks of edits looked like

Job lists (W/E 10/31 to 11/21)	Cells
Start times typed or changed	584
Jobs added	381
Jobs removed (most came back seconds later)	351
NAME filled or cleared (picks)	230
Description	108
Cover reason · Assigned driver	90 · 47
Pick lists	**Cells**
Call-in times	518
Pick numbers	473
Job / status	257

- **A week is built Sunday to Wednesday,** 13 to 10 days before it ends (72% of all job-list edits), in sessions around noon, 3 PM and early evening. Bid day, Thursday, is the names going in from 7 AM.
- **A new job goes in one cell at a time:** number, reason, five start times, description. That's 8 saves, and until this month each one was a notification on the admins' phones. On 11/10 that was 88 in a day.
- **Inserting a row** used to make every job under it leave the app until the new row's first cell was typed (17 jobs gone and back, several times, on 11/9), and drivers were told a job on their list was removed. The app now reads straight past a blank row, so insert rows wherever they belong.
- **Renumbering cascades:** one driver's number changes and everyone after moves. Three quarters of all pick-list edits are times and numbers. On 11/10, about 45 rows of the 11/21 list changed four times inside one minute.

SLICs staff (admins and dispatch in the app)

- **Never edit the sheet to fix the app.** If the sheet is wrong, dispatch corrects it. If the sheet is right and the app isn't, that's a bug: tell the SLICs admin.
- **Admin → Covers** is the hub. Cover Jobs has Refresh, the list of changes and the hide button. Cover Reports is where drivers' "Report a problem" lands.
- **A week won't appear?** Press Refresh on Cover Jobs: the message names what's off (no tab with that date, a title with another week, no jobs).
- **Admin → Jobs** shows when the app last heard from the sheet. It warns after two silent days.
- **Notifications are digests now.** "Cover jobs" and "Job changes" arrive once the sheet has been quiet for 15 minutes, saying where things ended up, and at most once an hour while edits keep coming. Picks are their own kind, "Cover picks", off unless you turn it on in your profile.
- **Bid day moved?** Set it on Cover Jobs as soon as dispatch says so. Reminders follow it.

Cover drivers

- **Covers is for reference.** Dispatch and the sheet decide. Call dispatch at your call-in time and ask what's available.
- **Your place and call-in time can move** until bid day. The app tells you the final ones once the list settles.
- **"Taken" means a name is on that job in the sheet.** A job can reopen. Your list isn't a pick: it's your own order to read off on the call.
- **You see only the jobs you can bid on.** Shifter and sleeper jobs aren't shown.
- **Not on the week's list and should be?** Tap "This is a mistake". **Something else wrong?** Tap "Report a problem". Both reach the admins, who check with dispatch.